

Missouri. These exploits gained Brown an infamous reputation and the nickname “Old Osawatomie Brown.”

## **Funding the raid**

Brown now seized upon the idea of inciting slave insurrection. He believed that if slaves rose up in great numbers, the economy of the South would collapse. In spite of his actions in Kansas, he traveled openly in New England, routinely appearing at abolitionist meetings and private parties. His exploits and appearance—simple clothing and an intensity of expression—attracted those tired of simply talking about slavery. One by one, Brown gathered a small group of radical abolitionists, six in all, who would support and fund his fight against slavery. The “Secret Six” were Thomas Wentworth Higginson, a minister and future Civil War officer; Dr. Samuel Gridley Howe, a Boston physician; Reverend Theodore Parker, a renowned speaker and Unitarian minister; Franklin Sanborn, a friend of Thoreau and Emerson; Gerrit Smith, a wealthy reformer and philanthropist who had previously given Brown land in the Adirondacks; and George Luther Stearns, a key financier of the Emigrant Aid Company, which funded settlement of Kansas by anti-slavery homesteaders.

**Brown's raid and death inspired an unknown writer or writers to compose the marching song, "John Brown's Body." By the outbreak of the Civil War, it was already a favorite with Union troops.**